HEALTH

Trans surgeries increase risk of mental health conditions, suicidal ideations: study

Gender dysphoria patients experienced ‘heightened psychological distress’ two years after surgery



By **Melissa Rudy** · **Fox News**

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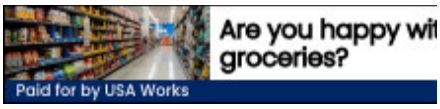


This story discusses suicide. If you or someone you know is having thoughts of suicide, please contact the Suicide & Crisis Lifeline at 988 or 1-800-273-TALK (8255).

So-called "gender-affirming surgery" could lead to potentially dangerous mental health effects, a new study has found.

Transgender individuals face "heightened psychological distress," including depression, anxiety and suicidal ideation, "partly due to stigma and lack of gender affirmation," as stated in the study, which

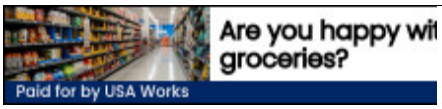


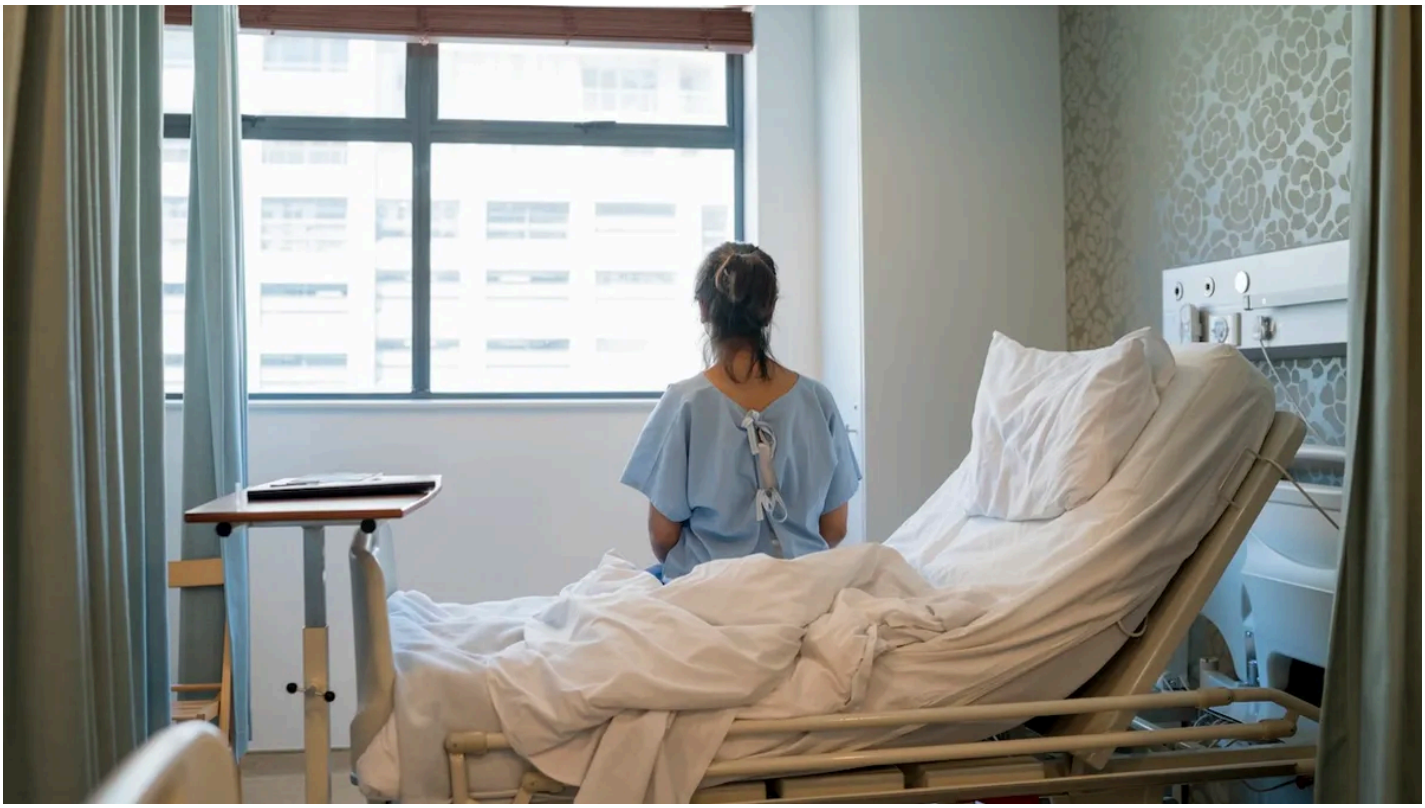


Researchers from the University of Texas set out to determine the mental health impacts from transgender people who underwent "gender-affirming surgery."

GENDER DYSPHORIA AND EATING DISORDERS HAVE SKYROCKETED SINCE PANDEMIC, REPORT REVEALS: 'RIPPLE EFFECTS'

The study focused on 107,583 patients 18 and over with gender dysphoria, some who underwent surgery and others who did not.





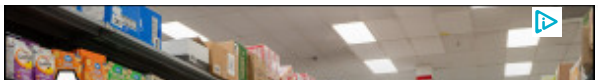
"Gender-affirming surgery" could lead to dangerous mental health effects, a new study has found. (iStock)

They determined rates of depression, anxiety, suicidal ideation and substance-use disorders were "significantly higher" among those who underwent surgery, assessed two years later.

Males with surgery had depression rates of 25% compared to males without surgery (11.5%). Anxiety rates among that group were 12.8% compared to 2.6%.

> **Depression, anxiety, suicidal ideation and substance-use disorders were "significantly higher" among those who underwent surgery.**

The same differences were seen among females, as those with surgery had 22.9% depression rates compared to 14.6% in the non-surgical group.



Females who underwent surgery also had anxiety rates of 10.5% compared to 7.1% without surgery.



The study focused on 107,583 patients 18 and over with gender dysphoria, some who underwent surgery and others who did not. (iStock)

Surgeries that aimed to "feminize individuals" showed "particularly high" rates of depression and substance abuse two years after the procedures, the study found.

"Findings suggest the necessity for gender-sensitive mental health support following gender-affirming surgery to address post-surgical psychological risks," the researchers wrote.

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‘Not a cure-all’

Jonathan Alpert, a Manhattan-based psychotherapist and author, said the study findings highlight the "often overlooked" psychological risks that accompany gender-affirming surgery.

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"While these surgeries can be critical in helping individuals align their physical appearance with their gender identity, they are not a cure-all for the mental health challenges many transgender individuals face," Alpert, who was not involved in the study, told Fox News Digital.

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‘GENDER-AFFIRMING’ TREATMENTS DON’T BENEFIT YOUTH, SAYS PEDIATRICIANS GROUP: ‘IRREVERSIBLE CONSEQUENCES’

"These findings suggest that surgery alone doesn’t eliminate the complex psychological burdens that stem from societal stigma and personal struggles with identity," he went on.

"In fact, taking a scalpel to treat a psychological disorder can sometimes lead to more issues, as the study results are elucidating."





"This isn't about politics and ideology — it's about health, longevity, and making sure people don't undergo drastic, life-altering procedures only to regret them." (iStock)

Florida neurosurgeon Dr. Brett Osborn, who also was not part of the study, agreed that "surgery is no guarantee of happiness."

"We're often told that gender-affirming surgery is essential for alleviating gender dysphoria — but what happens when the euphoria fades?" he said in an interview with Fox News Digital.

"The key question remains: Is the surgery itself causing distress, or are preexisting mental health issues driving people toward it? Correlation or causation? No one knows."

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A 2022 study showed that around 1.4 million American adults identify as transgender and about 0.6% of all American adults experience gender dysphoria.

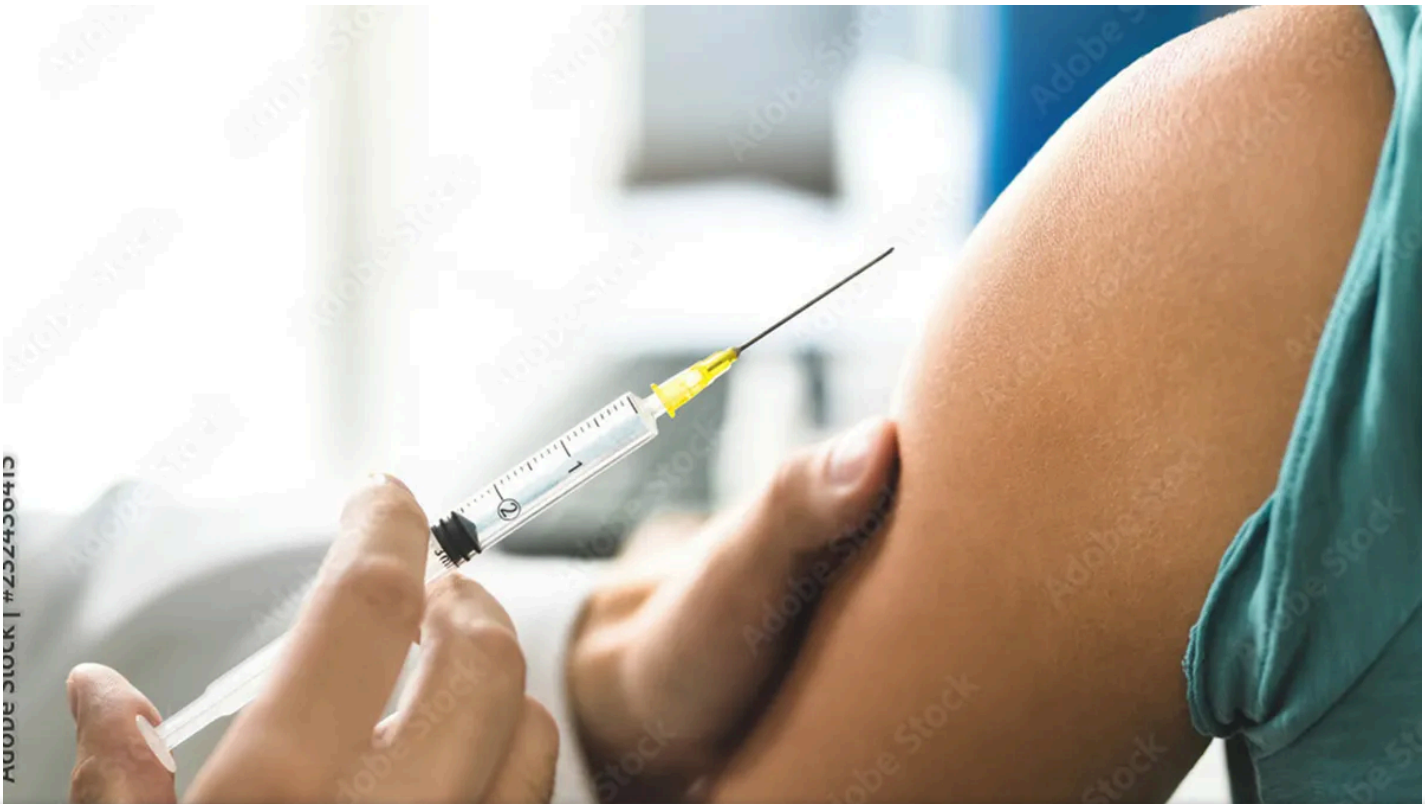
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"The dramatic upward trend of gender dysphoria among young people in recent years should raise serious questions about the role of cultural and social influences," Alpert said.

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"While increased awareness has made it easier for some children to express their struggles, we cannot ignore the possibility that social contagion, along with peer influence and social media, may be contributing to this surge."



management." (Adobe Stock)

Both experts caution against rushing into surgery or other irreversible decisions.

Teens who are being treated for gender dysphoria should be "properly supported and treated with compassion" without being pressured into making "life-altering" medical decisions, Alpert advised.



> **"You don’t amputate a limb because of temporary pain, and you certainly don’t permanently alter your body without exhausting every other option first."**

Osborn also stressed the need for comprehensive psychological evaluations, especially for those with preexisting mental health challenges. Mental health support, lifestyle modifications and counseling should all take precedence before surgery, not after, he said.

"You don’t amputate a limb because of temporary pain, and you certainly don’t permanently alter your body without exhausting every other option first," he said.



The doctors stressed the need for comprehensive psychological evaluations, especially for those with preexisting mental health challenges. (iStock)

Osborn expressed the same cautions about hormone therapy — "we're talking about irreversible changes that demand lifelong management."



"This isn't about politics and ideology — it's about health, longevity, and making sure people don't undergo drastic, life-altering procedures only to regret them," he said.

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"That said, to a great degree, the burden is on us physicians who took an oath to first do no harm."



Mark Trammell, executive director of The Center for American Liberty, which provides legal representation to people who are de-transitioning after trans surgeries, provided the below statement to Fox News Digital.

> **"Surgery alone doesn’t eliminate the complex psychological burdens that stem from societal stigma and personal struggles with identity."**

"The findings of this study should serve as a wake-up call. But for the young detransitioners we represent in lawsuits against gender clinics, these statistics are their lived reality," he said.

"Their so-called 'gender-affirming care' did not alleviate their distress — it created new mental health struggles and, for many, introduced suicidal thoughts for the first time. This is why we are fighting to hold those responsible accountable."

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Fox News Digital reached out to the study researchers requesting comment.